

Individuals and legal entities

Roman Antonov (AI Senior Developer, contractor)

Szilard Szegedi (Project Manager)

Project Timber (Company client)

Dispute Case #1

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1. Common statements

1. Roman A.'s working contract on the Upwork platform was suspended without any notification or explanation on 22 February 2026.
2. Roman A. has an agreement with Szilard S. to work only directly through each other, which Roman A. has never violated (dated August 2025, [Agreement with Szilard](#))
3. Roman A. continuously, regularly, and consistently reported all development progress to Szilard S., never rejected his priorities, and never declined Szilard S. video meeting requests.
4. At the moment of contract suspension, the system was operational and secured behind an authentication layer. The active chatbot version on 22 February 2026 was properly deployed and protected, and no critical security issues were reported or documented at that time. All of this is documented and can be verified via [GitHub commits](#).
5. This is the second time Roman A.'s contract has been stopped in the same unexpected manner, indicating a repeated pattern of contract suspension without prior notice.
6. Roman A.'s work is highly qualified, as proven by certifications (Microsoft, Google, and other), degrees, and completed project history.
7. Roman A. has received multiple personal emails from Mr. William Walton (Project Timber CEO) emphasizing his skills, expertise, and talent, and expressing ongoing support (all documented).
8. Roman A. remains open to helping, resolving issues, and continuing collaboration. Szilard S. is aware of this and understands the required next steps.
9. If Szilard S. decides, he can immediately engage Roman A. to restore the system. The delay is not on Roman A.'s side.
10. Roman A. experienced repeated delays in communication from Szilard S., in some cases lasting up to a week, including during critical periods when the system required upgrades. During these times, Roman A. continued to maintain the system independently.
11. Roman A.'s only interest is to see the system healthy, operational, and to be proud of the work delivered.
12. Roman A. invested significant personal funds to maintain system stability, including the use of premium-tier AI tools (approximately \$200-\$300 per month).
13. Every minute of Roman A.'s work is documented with screenshots in the Upwork work diary and can be reviewed.
14. Roman A. always prioritized tasks created by Szilard S. as the highest priority, immediately stop any other tasks if such new Szilard S. priority has been appearing.

15. Roman A.'s work was tracked on an hourly basis and did not include full project ownership or delivery guarantees. Responsibility for overall project management, prioritization, and completion remained with the project manager Szilard S.
16. Before starting long-term chatbot upgrades (approximately one month of work), Roman A. notified Szilard S., who agreed that this work was necessary (January – February 2026).
17. Roman A. continuously maintained and monitored system health daily for the last 6 months, without breaks or days off — a key factor in system stability.
18. This statement is provided to support a fair assessment of responsibilities and to facilitate a prompt and balanced resolution.
19. After contract suspension, Roman A. was no longer authorized or engaged to maintain or monitor the system. Any system changes or degradation after that point occurred outside of Roman A.'s operational control.
20. Roman A. has consistently expressed willingness to restore and stabilize the system under a proper agreement and clear coordination.

2. First Contract Suspension – Communication and Coordination Issues

Roman A. started working on Project Timber on 4 April 2025 and actively collaborated with employees and stakeholders, including participation in group meetings.

After approximately three weeks of work, the contract weekly limit was reduced to 5 hours without prior discussion, notification, or explanation. This change significantly impacted the ability to continue development in a consistent and effective manner.

During this period, Roman A. attempted to clarify the situation via Slack, email, and Upwork but did not receive responses for an extended period of time.

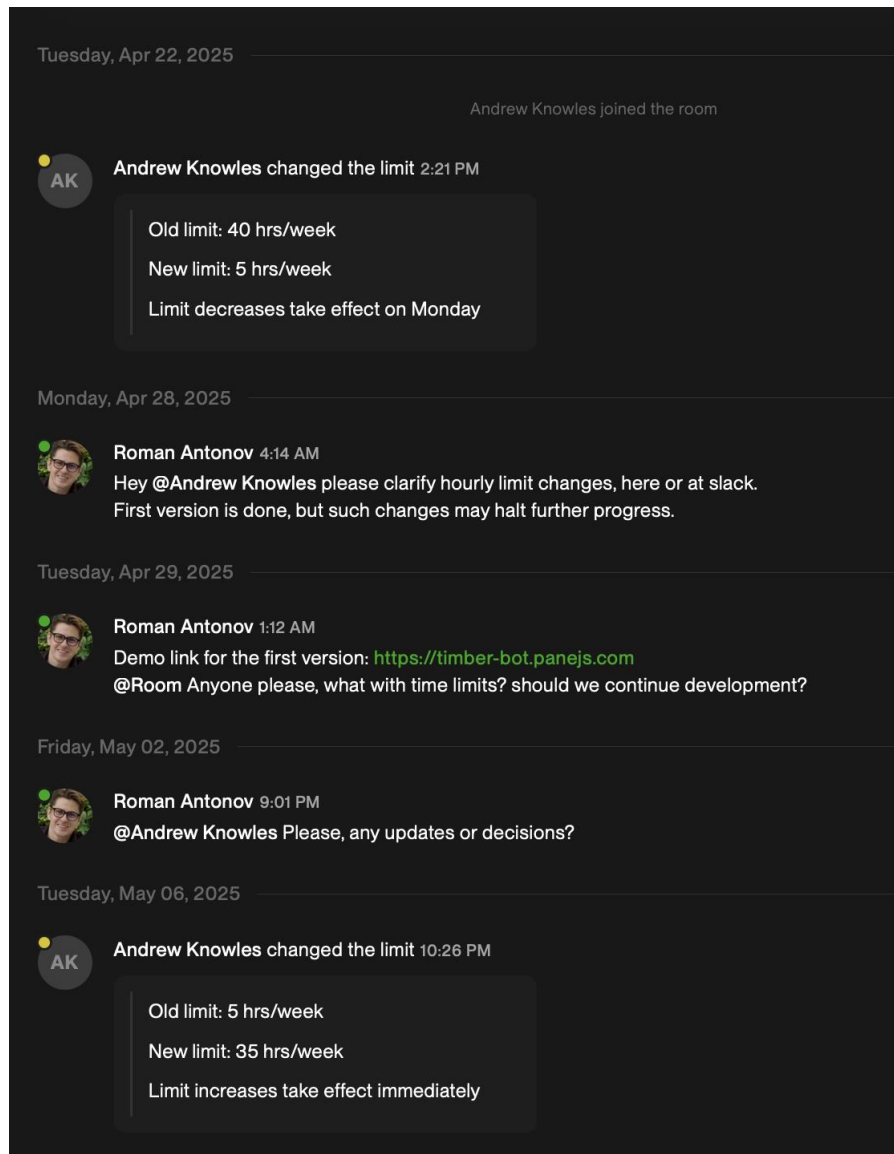
Between 22 April 2025 and 6 May 2025, there was no clear communication regarding whether development should continue or be paused, creating uncertainty around project direction and responsibilities.

Additionally, it was unclear who was operating under Andrew K.'s account at certain points, as later communication (March, subsequent period) was initiated by Paul Payne from that account.

Despite this interruption, Roman A. did not escalate the situation and continued cooperation once communication was re-established. The team acknowledged the work delivered and indicated that similar situations would not occur again.

Roman A. then resumed work on the project.

(Evidence: Upwork contract changes, Slack messages, screenshots attached)



3. Transition to Centralized Coordination with Szilard Szegedi

During June–August 2025, the number of stakeholders involved in the project increased significantly. While this reflected growing interest in the system and its development, it also created challenges in coordination and decision-making.

Roman A. received inputs and requests from multiple team members simultaneously, often with overlapping or conflicting priorities. This made it difficult to determine which directions should be followed and reduced overall development efficiency.

To address this, it was agreed that Szilard Szegedi would act as the primary point of coordination between Roman A. and Project Timber. This approach ensured clearer communication, consistent prioritization, and more effective progress on technical tasks.

4. Meetings and Communication Issues

During video meetings, Roman A. observed that certain interactions included elevated emotional responses and unpredictable communication patterns, which at times made structured technical discussions more difficult. This created additional pressure on the development process and reduced the ability to maintain the level of focus and stability required for complex technical work.

These patterns suggested a management approach characterized by high-pressure communication and urgency, which further impacted the consistency and predictability of development.

Roman A. also observed a consistently high turnover of staff throughout the project, with contributors frequently joining and leaving within relatively short periods. This created ongoing challenges in maintaining continuity, preserving system knowledge, and ensuring consistent execution of technical tasks.

Roman A.'s role in the project was as an AI system developer and technical contributor. From the beginning, Roman A. requested that meetings be scheduled in advance to allow proper planning and uninterrupted work on complex tasks requiring deep focus.

Ad hoc meeting requests were not always aligned with this approach, which impacted productivity and workflow consistency. Roman A. consistently attended all properly scheduled meetings. In contrast, there were multiple instances where meetings initiated by other stakeholders were delayed, started significantly later than scheduled, or not attended as planned.

5. Agreement with Szilard Szegedi and Contract Reinstatement

During this period, Roman A. received multiple repeated contact attempts within short timeframes, including several calls in a single hour, which created additional pressure on the working process.

Due to the increasing pressure and communication challenges, Roman A. raised concerns with Szilard Szegedi and proposed either a temporary pause or termination of collaboration to avoid further disruption.

As a result, it was agreed that Roman A. would continue working under a structured coordination model, with Szilard Szegedi acting as the primary point of contact. Szilard S. requested Roman A. to continue collaboration under these conditions.

This agreement is documented via meeting records and supporting materials (screenshots and video evidence attached).

During discussions, it was also noted by Szilard S. that similar situations had occurred previously with other developers, indicating a recurring pattern within the project environment.

Roman A. expressed concern regarding public criticism of his work without clear explanation or technical clarification. To avoid contributing to further tension and to maintain professional standards, Roman A. chose to temporarily close the contract at that time.

Subsequently, the contract was re-established on 29 September 2025 under the role of “AI & Automation Senior Developer,” reflecting an updated scope of responsibilities.

The completed contract period prior to this transition was accompanied by 5-star public feedback, demonstrating a positive working relationship and satisfaction with Roman A.’s work as of August 2025.

(Evidence: meeting notes screenshot, video recording, Upwork contract history, client review attached)

Client's feedback to you

★★★★★ 5.0

Roman did an amazing job for us, he implemented multiple systems for us and we are more than happy with the results.



Notes from “Szilard & Roman 15 min quick call”

These notes have been sent to the host and co-hosts.

[Open meeting notes](#)

The content was auto-generated on August 14, 2025, 6:49 PM
GMT+07:00 and may contain errors.

Summary

Roman Antonov informed Szegedi Szilard of their decision to take a one-month break from all collaboration due to management pressure and William's behavior. Roman Antonov expressed concerns about William's publicizing payment issues and emotional instability, fearing potential actions due to William's connections. Szegedi Szilard assured Roman Antonov that they would prevent William from writing a bad review on Upwork and prevent any harm. Roman Antonov proposed transferring all project components within a week and discontinuing their contract, offering to continue as a consultant. Szegedi Szilard suggested a shorter two-week break instead of a full month. Both parties agreed to a meeting on Monday to finalize the Upwork contract and discuss the transition, with Szegedi Szilard ensuring William would not directly contact Roman Antonov.

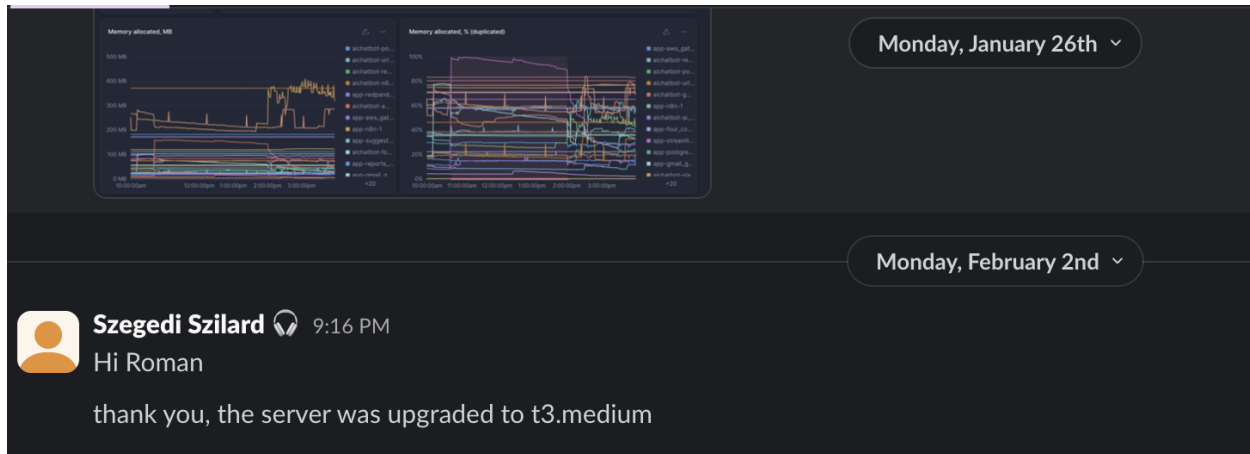
Link to recorded video meeting between Roman A. and Szilard S. is [available here](#)

6. Project Coordination and Communication with Szilard Szegedi

At the initial stages of the project, communication and coordination with Szilard Szegedi were active and effective. Over time, however, the level of engagement and responsiveness decreased.

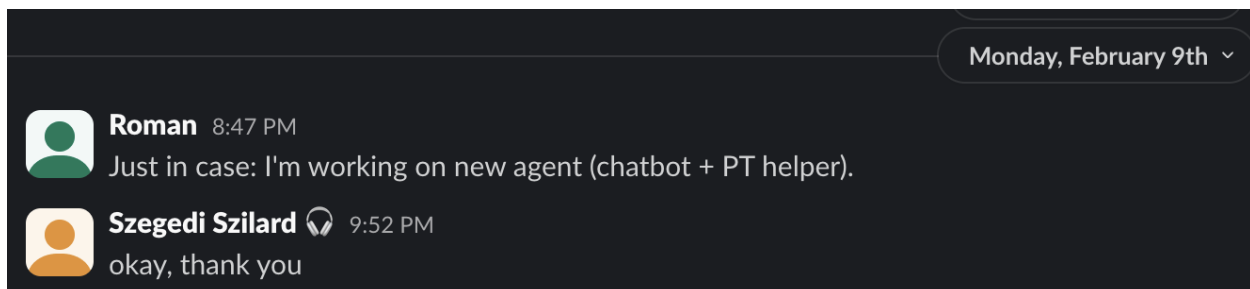
Starting from late January 2026, communication delays became more noticeable. In some cases, responses were delayed for extended periods, including instances where no response was received for up to week, even during periods when the system required

updates or attention.



In February 2026, proactive coordination from the project management side was limited. There were no requests for progress updates or structured follow-up on development stages. Roman A. continued to provide regular updates and progress reports; however, responses were often brief and did not include further direction or prioritization.

From Roman A.'s side, work remained transparent and structured throughout this period. Roman A. maintained a visible task list (as documented in the Upwork work diary) and kept the Monday board consistently updated with tasks, progress, and tracking information.



This reduction in active coordination and feedback impacted the ability to align priorities and ensure timely decision-making within the project.

7. Second Contract Suspension – Reported Reasons and Observations

The exact reason for the second contract suspension has not been formally communicated to Roman A.

Several informal explanations were mentioned by different stakeholders:

- It was suggested by Szilard Szegedi that the suspension may be related to limited responses in public chat channels. Roman A. was not assigned responsibility to manage public communication and was primarily focused on technical development. Nevertheless, Roman A. responded to public messages when time allowed and when input was relevant.
- It was also suggested by Paul Payne that the issue may be related to an unauthenticated version of the chatbot. However, this version was deployed after the contract suspension as part of a temporary demo/testing setup and was not active in production at the time of suspension.

Following the re-establishment of the contract after the first suspension, Roman A. received several direct communications from Mr. William Walton expressing support, positive feedback on his work, and encouragement to continue collaboration (evidence attached).



William Walton <william.walton@projecttimber.co.uk>
to me ▾

Thu, Oct 2, 2025, 12:49 PM ☆ 😊 ↩ ⋮

Hey Roman,

I want to acknowledge your excellent contributions to Project Timber. Your talent is evident in your work, and the entire team, including myself, is very grateful for it.

This year has brought significant challenges, particularly the necessary layoffs due to the UK's economic climate. These were difficult decisions, but some redundancies were essential for business alignment. The experience has been tough on everyone in the factory.

Despite these difficulties, I am eager to contribute more to your work, as it's part of a larger strategic initiative that I believe you should be involved in. I'm especially inspired by your work with AI and would appreciate it if you could show me how you developed it, beyond just bug fixes and repairs. My professional experience includes developing a custom SQL CRM for a larger business (my former business with my brother, where I worked from the age of 16), and I believe my background could be beneficial in our brainstorming sessions.

Please know that you are supported, and collaboration is a core part of our operations. I genuinely believe that an open conversation would significantly benefit our working relationship and alleviate any lingering awkwardness.

Yesterday, I met with an AI entrepreneur and would love to share my experience with you and hear your feedback. Would you be open to having a conversation? Szilard can be in the call also if you like... through whatsapp or even FaceTime audio.

On an additional note, your Russian background intrigues me. My ex-partner, Anastasia, is from St Petersburg. Although I've never visited Russia, my family has over the years with timber buying. We have a long-standing history with many timber mills in Russia, and once the war ends and sanctions are lifted, I'd love to revisit some of our old mills and old contacts.

I hope we can have a WhatsApp call soon.

Ps. Sz will continue to work with you directly as I believe you work together nicely.

Thanks,
William



Szegedi Szilard 📞 6:47 PM

Wednesday, January 7th ▾

thank you for your time Roman. William just called me and he is really happy with the work you did the monday board integration with care inbox?

Based on the consistency of these supportive communications after the first contract re-establishment, it appears unlikely that the second suspension (22 February 2026) was

initiated by Mr. William Walton as a direct response to Roman A.'s performance. This further emphasizes the lack of clarity regarding the source of the suspension decision.

Based on the available information, no clear or consistent explanation has been provided regarding the suspension decision.

Additionally, it is unclear which individual initiated the contract suspension, as multiple team members appear to operate under the same Upwork client account.

This lack of a clearly defined reason and decision-making authority makes it difficult to attribute responsibility for the current system of state to Roman A.

8. System Status and Infrastructure Responsibility

At the moment of contract suspension, the system was operational and functioning as expected.

Following the suspension, Roman A. was no longer engaged or authorized to maintain or monitor the system, in accordance with Upwork terms and the absence of an active contract. See [Upwork Terms of service](#)

During development, certain infrastructure components were provisioned and maintained by Roman A. on his own resources (including storage services, vector database solutions, and API usage), with the intention of reducing delays and optimizing operational costs for Project Timber.

To ensure long-term stability and proper ownership, Roman A. proposed a full infrastructure migration plan in August 2025, immediately after the first contract re-establishment. The purpose of this plan was to transfer all critical components to Project Timber's infrastructure and eliminate dependency risks.

The migration plan remains available:

<https://romanrr.notion.site/Project-Timber-Migration-Plan-253e890c232880439f35e494d584e811?pvs=74>

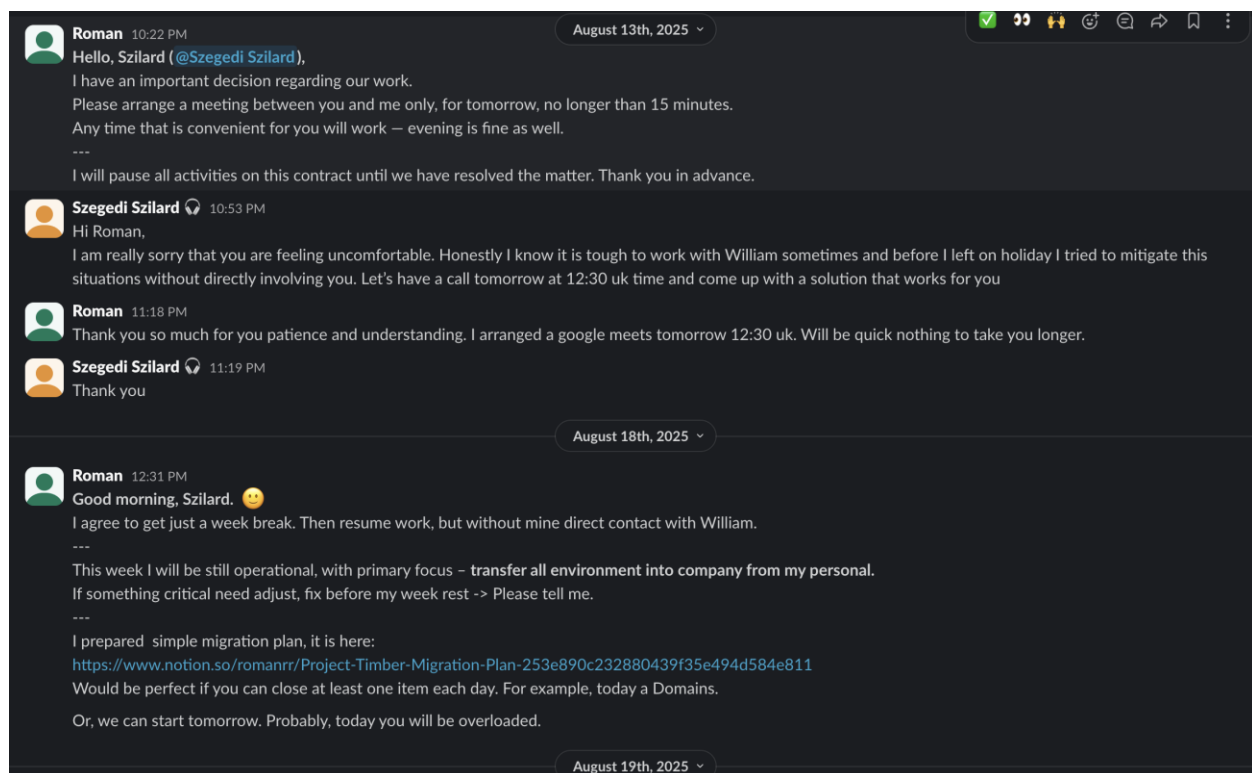
However, no structured prioritization, execution steps, or follow-through were established to complete the migration.

The contract was suspended on 22 February 2026 before the migration process was completed.

After the contract suspension, Roman A. discontinued the use of his personal infrastructure resources and API tokens, as continued usage would result in ongoing personal costs without an active agreement or compensation. This action reflects standard operational practice when a contract is no longer active.

As a result, the system's current partially operational state reflects the absence of ongoing maintenance and the lack of completed infrastructure transfer, rather than the condition of the system during the active contract period.

This discontinuation was a standard commercial consequence of contract suspension, not a hostile act.



9. System Authentication and Deployment State

At the moment of contract suspension, no clarification was requested regarding the current development stage or deployment status. The contract was suspended without prior coordination or transition planning.

As a result, the system remained in its latest development state, reflecting the current stage of ongoing work at that time.

The deployment of this version followed the existing development and deployment workflow, including automated processes, and was not the result of a specific post-suspension action.

The authentication layer was part of the planned development roadmap and was scheduled to be finalized in the following days. Therefore, the temporary absence of authentication in the development version reflects an intermediate stage of implementation, rather than a security omission or completed production configuration.

This situation resulted from the interruption of the development process, rather than from any deficiency in system design or intent.

10. System Recovery Requirements and Scope

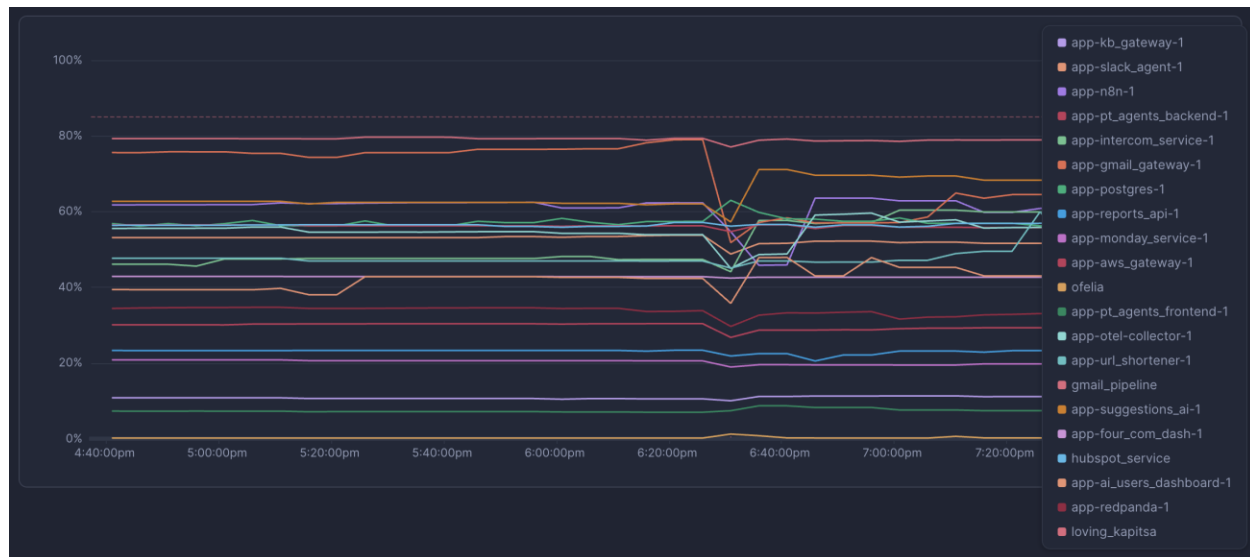
The system is currently partially operational. Due to a period of inactivity following the contract suspension, restoring it to a fully stable and production-ready state requires additional work.

Based on current understanding, the recovery process is expected to require approximately 1–2 weeks of work. A detailed review may identify additional requirements.

The initial scope of work includes:

- Full system review and health check across all services
- Identification and replacement of API keys and credentials with company-owned resources
- Review of third-party infrastructure components and preparation for migration
- Execution of infrastructure migration and stabilization across all services
- Completion and verification of the authentication layer

The system architecture is complex and includes 19+ microservices, 10+ external integrations, and 5+ databases. Due to this complexity, stabilization requires careful monitoring and validation of all interconnected components.



Full infrastructure migration and system re-stabilization can be completed within approximately one week by Roman A., who is fully familiar with the system architecture. A developer without prior involvement would require significantly more time to understand dependencies and restore full functionality.

During the active contract period, Roman A. performed daily system monitoring (minimum 1 hour per day), including checks of call processing, email workflows, resource usage, container health, chatbot functionality, and external integrations. This ongoing maintenance was a key factor in maintaining system stability.

11. Upwork Terms of Service and Responsibility Scope

Roman A.'s responsibility covered the system only during the active contract period.

Following the suspension of the hourly contract, Roman A. was no longer authorized or engaged to maintain, monitor, or operate the system.

In accordance with Upwork Terms of Service, contractors are expected to stop work immediately when a contract is paused or ended, unless a separate agreement is established.

Therefore, any system changes, degradation, or operational issues occurring after the contract suspension fall outside the scope of Roman A.'s responsibility.

Reference:

<https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/211068348-What-to-do-if-your-contract-with-a-client-is-paused>

12. Public Feedback Considerations

1. Public feedback should reflect Roman A.'s work and conduct **during the active contract period**, rather than events that occurred after contract suspension or termination. During a pause, Upwork instructs freelancers to stop work immediately.
2. If feedback is provided for a closed contract, it should be based on the work **delivered and the project state during the active period of that contract**. Roman A.'s responsibility did not extend to unpaid post-suspension maintenance. Upwork states that paused contracts prevent billing and that work should stop until the contract is resumed.
3. Public feedback is optional. Roman A. did not force or demand feedback, and only politely noted that this option exists.
4. Public feedback has a direct impact on a freelancer's public work history and professional reputation.

References:

<https://support.upwork.com/hc/en-us/articles/211068348-What-to-do-if-your-contract-with-a-client-is-paused>

13. Szilard Szegedi's Position Regarding Public Feedback

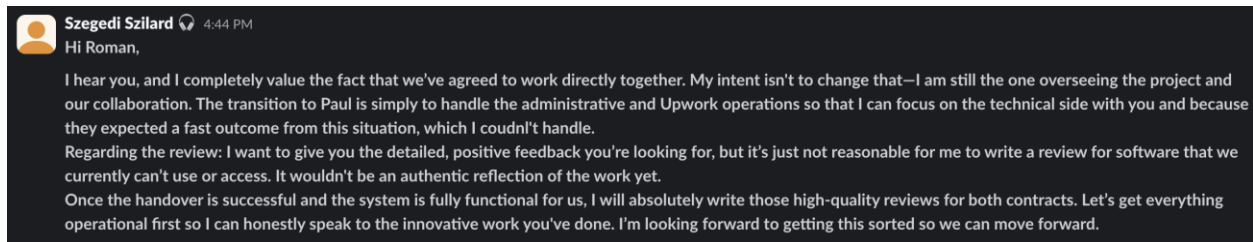
Roman A. sent a polite notice that public feedback for the previously completed contract would be appreciated and indicated a preference to receive that feedback before starting any new contract. Roman A. did not force or demand feedback and only raised this as a professional request.

Public feedback for a completed contract should reflect the work performed during that contract's active period. It should not be based on events that occurred after suspension or termination, especially where no active hourly contract remained in place and no further authorized maintenance was being performed. Upwork's guidance states that work should stop when a contract is paused, and end-of-contract feedback is left within the review process for that specific contract.

In response, Szilard S. stated that he could provide feedback for the completed contract only after a new maintenance and migration contract was started and completed. This

position appears inconsistent with the purpose of end-of-contract feedback, which is intended to reflect the work already delivered under the completed contract.

Szilard S. also stated that he was not currently authorized to operate on Upwork. However, in the same discussion, he indicated that he would later be able to leave feedback after the new contract was completed. These statements appear contradictory regarding his claimed inability to act on the platform while still conditioning old-contract feedback on completion of a new contract.



As a result, Roman A. understood that feedback for the already completed contract was being withheld and linked to acceptance and completion of separate future work under different terms. From Roman A.'s perspective, this created pressure and the appearance of manipulative leverage in relation to public feedback.

References: [Upwork_Public_feedback](#)

14. Roman A.'s Dispute Resolution Proposal

An initial resolution proposal was presented but rejected by Szilard S., who stated that he no longer had authorization to manage Upwork contracts. Roman A.'s proposed resolution was as follows:

1. Szilard S. would send Roman A. a new hourly-rate contract with a minimum weekly limit of 25 hours.
2. Roman A. would complete the required migrations, restore all critical parts of the system to an operational state, and provide a gentle, well-documented handover of services and infrastructure to Szilard S.
3. Roman A. and Project Timber would conclude the collaboration on professional and positive terms.

Note: Roman A. started this work directly with Szilard S., and the project was developed under Szilard S.'s coordination and observation. For that reason, any further work under similar terms should be carried out only under Szilard S.'s direct coordination and with his

full control over the Upwork contract, to reduce the risk of repeated contract suspensions, miscommunication, or process instability.

Roman A. may consider an alternative person for a new **Maintenance & Handover** contract (e.g. Paul Payne), but only under different terms and rates, and only after proper public feedback is provided by Szilard S. for the previous completed work, which was delivered to a high standard during the active contract period prior to suspension.

Roman A. also reserves the right to consider an increased rate for any further recovery, maintenance, or handover of work, taking into account the additional stress, loss of income, uncertainty, and disruption caused by the events of the past month.

15. Legal and Platform Policy Considerations

1. Public statements or feedback concerning Roman A. should be accurate, genuine, and limited to the work performed during the active contract period. End-of-contract feedback is associated with the specific completed contract, and the platform requires that feedback be genuine and related to the contract.
2. Roman A.'s responsibility did not extend to unpaid post-suspension maintenance. Upwork's guidance states that when a contract is paused, work should stop immediately unless a separate agreement is established. Accordingly, events occurring after suspension should not be presented as if they were part of Roman A.'s active contractual performance.
3. Any materially false, misleading, or unsupported public statements regarding Roman A.'s work, qualifications, conduct, or responsibility may cause serious professional and commercial harm, including damage to reputation, loss of future opportunities, and financial impact.
4. If such statements are made publicly, Roman A. reserves the right to seek appropriate review and remedy through available procedures, and any other rights available under applicable law.
5. Roman A. expects that any public feedback or statement will be limited to verified facts and the active contract period only. Any materially false or misleading attribution of post-suspension system issues to Roman A. will be documented and may be challenged through legal procedures and other available legal channels.

16. Timeline

4 April 2025 — Roman A. started work on Project Timber and actively collaborated with employees and stakeholders, including participation in group meetings.

Approximately late April 2025 — After around three weeks of work, the weekly contract limit was reduced to 5 hours without prior discussion, notification, or explanation. This materially affected development continuity.

22 April 2025 – 6 May 2025 — Roman A. attempted to clarify the situation through Slack, email, and Upwork, but there was no clear communication on whether development should continue or pause.

May 2025 — Communication was later re-established, cooperation resumed, and Roman A. continued working on the project.

June–August 2025 — The number of involved stakeholders increased significantly, creating coordination issues, overlapping requests, and reduced development efficiency.

August 2025 — An agreement was established that Szilard Szegedi would serve as the primary coordination point between Roman A. and Project Timber. Roman A. followed this arrangement and did not violate it.

August 2025 — Roman A. proposed a migration plan intended to move infrastructure ownership to Project Timber and reduce future dependency risks.

September 2025 — Following communication pressure and coordination issues, Roman A. raised concerns and temporarily closed the contract to avoid further disruption.

29 September 2025 — The contract was re-established under the role “AI & Automation Senior Developer.” The completed prior contract period was accompanied by 5-star public feedback.

After 29 September 2025 — Mr. William Walton sent several supportive communications expressing positive feedback and encouragement to continue collaboration.

Late January 2026 — Communication delays from Szilard Szegedi became more noticeable, including periods of non-response lasting up to two weeks during technically important moments.

January–February 2026 — Roman A. notified Szilard Szegedi about the long-term chatbot upgrade work, and Szilard agreed that this work was necessary. Roman A. continued

reporting progress, maintaining the Monday board, and documenting work in the Upwork diary.

February 2026 — Proactive project coordination was limited. Roman A. continued to send updates, but responses were often brief and lacked further prioritization or direction.

22 February 2026 — Roman A.'s hourly contract was suspended for the second time without prior notice or formal explanation. At that moment, the system was operational, the active chatbot version was protected, and no critical security issue had been reported or documented.

Immediately after 22 February 2026 — Because the contract had been suspended, Roman A. was no longer authorized or engaged to maintain or monitor the system. Roman A. also discontinued the use of personal infrastructure resources and API tokens that had been subsidizing parts of the system.

After suspension — An unauthenticated demo/testing chatbot version was discussed by stakeholders as a possible issue, but this version was deployed after the suspension and was not the production state at the time of suspension.

After suspension — Stakeholders mentioned inconsistent informal explanations for the suspension, including public chat responsiveness and chatbot authentication, but no clear formal reason was ever provided. It also remained unclear who specifically initiated the suspension decision under the shared Upwork client account.

March 2026 — Szilard Szegedi indicated that feedback for the completed contract would be provided only after completion of a new maintenance and migration contract, while also stating that he was not authorized to operate Upwork contracts. Roman A. viewed these statements as contradictory.

20 March 2026 — Roman A.'s position remains that he is willing to restore, stabilize, and hand over the system under a proper new agreement with clear coordination and responsibility boundaries.

This timeline shows that the key operational risks arose from repeated contract interruption, incomplete migration, and absence of post-suspension maintenance authority, rather than from any proven failure of Roman A.'s work during the active contract period.